

M-77 and the art of JUGGLERY

With the renewed mandate, it is now the job of Team Manmohan to ensure that a Gandhi returns to power after a 25-year gap in 2014

| By Prabhu Chawla |

Now that we are left with hardly any superlative to describe the mandate, maybe it's time to talk business. After an exhaustive—and quite exhausting—exercise in cabinet formation, the rearmed Dr Manmohan Singh himself would like us to believe that he means some serious business this time. After all, a mandate for performance can be sustained only by performing better. As the prime minister's laboriously chosen colleagues lean back in their freshly "towelled" chairs, one unpleasant question remains: Are the *mantris* worthy of the mandate? Or, has the Doctor got the right prescription for India?

The question is inevitable because a government is only as good as the people who run it. When Nehru formed his first cabinet after the 1952 general elections, every member of his team was a qualified architect in the project of nation building. What India needs at the moment is a leadership that can rise above the expediencies of realpolitik—and a government that puts national interest above votebank politics.

What about Team Manmohan? It may be the cleanest we have got in recent years, but is it fit enough to face up to the challenges of the times? With 78 members, it's really bloated. The size could have been justified had

it been filled with the brightest and the youngest. India may be a country where half of its population is under 25 years of age, and Rahul Gandhi may be the singular force that made the Congress victory sensational, but this Cabinet is hardly brimming with youthful spirit. It was all about striking a balance between caste, regional and factional pressures. There was dash of social correctness too.

Not that the prime minister and his political boss were faced with a dearth of talent. There was an embarrassment of riches with 206 members in the Lok Sabha and 70 in the Upper House. Nine of the 31 Cabinet ministers are former chief ministers. Their collective experience in running big and small states could have been a major strength of this ministry. When the portfolios were announced, it was pretty obvious that those gentlemen were invited to the hallowed portals of Lutyens' Delhi not because of their administrative skills. They were reemployed out of regional compulsions. Former Jammu and Kashmir chief minister Farooq Abdullah was given new and renewable energy; former Himachal chief minister Virbhadra Singh was given steel; and former Maharashtra chief minister Vilasrao Deshmukh got the almost redundant heavy industry and public enterprises. And most surpris-

